

Q. So are you saying you have nothing to do with Afras now?

A. No, and contrary to news reports, they didn't pay for my hotel bills. I didn't send an aide to the Taj hotel, but I went myself and paid my bills through a credit card, I have stayed at the Taj 17 times before and that time the company paid the bills since I was the chairman. So this whole controversy is baseless.

Q. You stayed at the Taj for more than three months. Did you ask the Foreign Ministry to pay for your hotel bills?

A. I asked the ministry about what I was entitled to. Frankly, the ministry told me I was entitled to nothing. Had the ministry told me that I was entitled to Rs 500 a night, I would have taken that, but they didn't even tell me that. As an MP, I am entitled to stay in Kerala House and I sometimes use that room not for myself but for my party workers from my constituency.

Q. Your critics say that despite holding the Haj portfolio, you still can't visit Saudi Arabia to oversee Haj arrangements being a non-Muslim. Is that a handicap?

A. No. On the contrary, I have been praised by Muslim leaders for streamlining the Haj process. We have done some changes and more are to come

told him that 'you better grow a thicker skin'. And that is an appropriate line. I am growing a thicker skin for politics. I don't think anybody is a misfit in politics. My argument is that all those who fit the conventional image and those from different backgrounds should enter politics.

Q. Away from the controversies, you handle the Latin America and Africa portfolio, but do you think India is doing enough for this region?

"Sometimes the prime minister is willing to go abroad but people are not free to receive him."



RAVISH SAHANI/www.indiatodayimages.com

"I left a well-paying job and gave up my speaking fees. I have made a serious financial sacrifice."

next year.

Q. But in the heat of the controversy, did you ask yourself what were you doing in politics?

A. The only time I doubted myself was when I was running my election campaign. But even then, I kept telling myself that if I have to be in politics then I need to earn the right to do so.

Q. But do you feel you are a misfit in politics?

A. My wife and my mother were opposed to the idea of me entering politics, and they are still unhappy about my decision. But I recall what Natwar Singh told me when he entered politics. He said Indira Gandhi had once

A. There is a crying need for revival. Today, I met Latin American ambassadors and they feel that India has neglected them. This is a substantive feeling, which applies to Africa as well. Our problem is that our leadership is incredibly in demand, but their schedule is crowded. The prime minister is required to be in the country to focus on domestic issues as that's what the party wants at least when the elections are taking place in different states. Scheduling creates problems. Sometimes the prime minister is willing to go abroad more often but people are not free to receive him. The time has come to make a genuine effort to

transform the relationship. We are looking at newer areas of cooperation. For instance, Paraguay has recently offered us land for cultivation.

Q. Are you working on a Tharoor doctrine for these countries?

A. No, I am only steering the Manmohan doctrine. Our prime minister has a clear vision for foreign policy. I believe that the areas I have been entrusted with, there is a need to revitalise our foreign policy.

Q. What about Africa? There are allegations of corruption in India's lines of credit.

A. We have traditional ties with Africa, which have intensified in the last few years and they have praised our development model. Under the lines of credit, we have given them aid worth \$5.4 billion. I have not received any complaints but if there are allegations of corruption, we will investigate.

Q. What about the Gulf region? You think you need to change gear?

A. With the Gulf, we need to have a strong investment and a political relationship. In a structured and strategic way, we need to encourage more of our ministers to participate in foreign policy and they should be travelling to this region more often.

Q. So, after all the controversy do you want to reboot your stint in the Foreign Office?

A. I want to make some difference and demystify the process of Indian diplomacy so that we can reach out to the common people. We are reviving the Policy Planning Division from a backwater division to an active division, even though there is resistance. We will be working on concept papers on important strategic issues. My message is that the foreign policy is not for the Foreign Ministry, it is for the people.

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